Suslov, the senior assistant to the minister of foreign affairs, was calling. He said that a coded telegram had arrived from Dobrynin about a new conversation with Robert Kennedy," recalled Troianovsky. Decades later he remembered Kennedy's message as an ultimatum in all but form: the Americans were determined to get rid of the Soviet missile bases; the military was putting pressure on the president; time was running out; and a clear Soviet response was expected within one day. Troianovsky returned to the meeting room and read from his notes. Robert Kennedy was offering Khrushchev the Turkish missiles.[15]

In his memoirs, Khrushchev refers to the arrival of Dobrynin's cable as the climax of the crisis. If Troianovsky recalled Robert Kennedy's message as a form of ultimatum, Khrushchev remembered it as an appeal for mercy. In Khrushchev's retelling, Robert Kennedy begged Dobrynin to understand the peculiarities of the American political system and help the president find a way out of the crisis. "The president himself does not know how to get out of that situation, and the military is exerting strong pressure on him, insisting that he take military action with regard to Cuba, and the president's situation is becoming highly complicated," wrote Khrushchev, recalling the main points of the message years later. He was trying to prove that his retreat was in fact a maneuver in response to a plea from the Kennedy brothers. But that interpretation would come later. On the afternoon of October 28, he was eager to take the new deal as quickly as possible.[16]

Troianovsky remembered that in the middle of the discussions General Ivanov, the secretary of the Defense Council, was called to the telephone and reported to the Presidium that according to information picked up by the military, President Kennedy was to address the nation at 5:00 p.m. Moscow time. "[At] that moment those taking part in the meeting believed the worst, deciding that Kennedy would announce either an attack on Cuba or, what seemed more probable, the bombing of missile installations." They had to react promptly. The letter to Kennedy was not yet ready, but Khrushchev ordered Andrei Gromyko to cable Dobrynin right away with instructions to tell Robert Kennedy that Moscow was prepared to accept his brother's conditions. "Comrade Gromyko, we don't have the right to take risks. Once the president announces there will be an invasion, he won't be